

QS World University Rankings – New Zealand university results

Background

Quacquarelli Symonds (QS) has published university rankings since the 2005 edition. Between the 2005 and 2010 editions, it produced university rankings for Times Higher Education. Since the 2011 edition, QS has published university rankings under its own banner.

The 2026 QS World University Rankings were released in June 2025, with the results published at www.topuniversities.com.¹

Method and criticisms

For the 2026 World University Rankings, QS has published rankings for more than 1,500 institutions. Over time, QS has introduced several changes to the methodology. For instance, in the 2024 edition QS introduced three new indicators and altered the weights of existing ones. The new modifications make assessing any changes in ranking over the past few years difficult as they may simply reflect the impact of the new methodology rather than any changes in underlying performance. The nine measures (and their weightings) used by QS to generate the World University Rankings are presented in Table 1.

The measurements are grouped under five lenses. The first is research-related and encompasses *Academic Reputation* and *Citation per Faculty*. The second one relates to post-study outcomes and includes *Employer Reputation* and *Employment Outcomes*.

The most recent changes saw the weighting for the Academic Reputation reduce from 40 percent to 30 percent and the weighting for the Employer Reputation from 10 percent to 15 percent. These measures are produced from reputation surveys, and the high weightings QS applies have been criticised as it is argued this represents a measure of perceived performance rather than actual performance. From the 2016 edition, QS have used

survey responses from the last five years rather than the three years used previously.

QS uses citations per faculty member to measure the research performance of universities. From the 2016 edition, QS have applied weightings to citations to adjust for the different rates of citation that exist in different broad faculty areas. The previous approach, which did not weight citations, favoured universities with a focus on the sciences and medicine.

The *Employment Outcomes* measure was introduced in the 2024 edition and combines the employment rate of universities' graduates with the alumni impact index, which measures how influential graduates are.

Learning experience (*Faculty Student Ratio*) is measured by the number of students per faculty, the logic being that smaller class sizes result in better quality teaching.

QS acknowledges that this measure is not comparable with a classroom assessment of learning but argues that it is the only globally available proxy measure of teaching performance, and that class sizes and teaching quality are highly correlated. The weighting for this component has been reduced from 20 percent to 10 percent since the 2024 edition.

However, a link between student-to-staff ratios and teaching quality has been questioned in the literature. Further, in using this measure, QS does not consider the discipline mix of a university, which can influence its student to staff ratio.

The three measures of global engagement are: the proportion of international staff at an institution (*International Faculty Ratio*), the proportion of international students at an institution (*International Student Ratio*) and the *International Research Network*. The latter was introduced in the 2024 edition and accounts for the number of international partners by their locations. QS considers that a

¹ QS has a naming convention where the year assigned to the ranking is one year in advance of when the results were actually published. For example, the 2026 QS World University Rankings were actually released in June 2025.

higher proportion of international staff and students indicates that a university is a desirable destination. These measures favour universities in English-speaking countries, as international students prefer to study in English, the lingua franca for commerce and for research.

Finally, the last measure introduced in the 2024 edition is called *Sustainability*. This is an index derived from the QS Sustainability rankings, and it reflects the intentions of universities towards social and environmental sustainability.

Table 1

Component measures used in QS World University Ranking

Lens	Weight	Criteria	Indicator	Weight
Research and Discovery	50%	Academic reputation	A survey of academics that asks respondents to identify universities they consider best in research. The survey results are subject to weighting by QS and survey respondents cannot vote for their own institution. From the 2016 edition QS have used responses from the last five years instead of the last three years.	30%
		Citations per faculty	The number of citations over the last five years divided by the number of faculty full-time equivalent (FTE) staff. The SCOPUS dataset is used to count the citations. From the 2016 edition, QS have weighted citations by broad faculty area.	20%
Employability and Outcomes	20%	Employer reputation	A survey of employers where respondents are asked to identify institutions they consider have high-quality graduates. The survey results are subject to weighting by QS. From the 2016 edition, QS have used responses from the last five years instead of the last three years.	15%
		Employment outcomes	An index that combines the graduate employment rate with a measure of Alumni impact. This was introduced in the 2024 edition.	5%
Global Engagement	15%	International faculty ratio	The proportion of faculty members who have a foreign nationality.	5%
		International student ratio	The proportion of students who have a foreign nationality.	5%
		International research network	An index that accounts for the number of research partners and the number of their research locations. This was introduced in the 2024 edition.	5%
Learning Experience	10%	Faculty/student ratio	The number of FTE students per equivalent full-time faculty.	10%
Sustainability	5%	Sustainability	An index obtained from the results of the QS Sustainability Rankings. This was introduced in the 2024 edition.	5%

Results

Table 2 and Figure 1 present the rankings for New Zealand universities in the QS World University Rankings. It is important to note that the scoring system used by QS to rank universities changed significantly in the 2008 edition of the rankings. There was another significant change to the methodology in the 2016 edition of the rankings and again in the 2024 edition.

Some of the key points of the 2026 edition of the QS rankings for New Zealand universities are:

- ▲ all eight New Zealand universities are ranked inside the top 500 by QS
- ▲ the University of Auckland is the top-ranked university and has been placed within the top 100 since the ranking began.

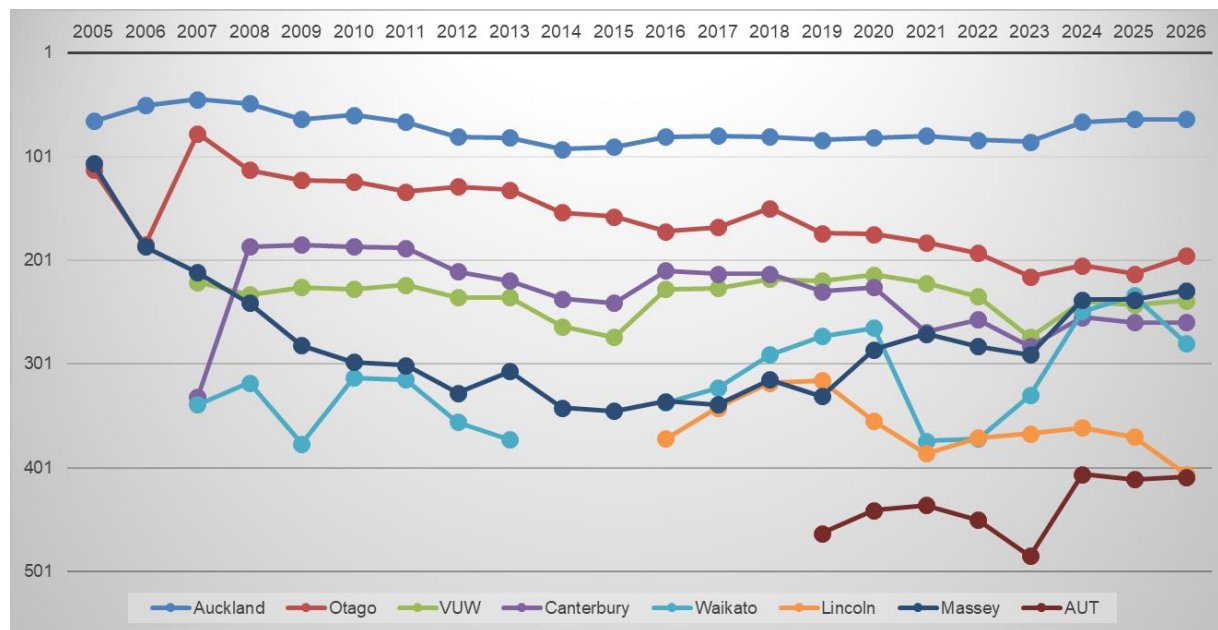
Table 2
QS World University Rankings for New Zealand universities

University	2005	2006	2007	Significant change in method	2008	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	Significant change in method	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	Significant change in method	2024	2025	2026
Auckland	67	52	46		50	65	61=	68	82	83	94	92=		82=	81	82=	85	83=	81	85=	87		68	65	65
Otago	114	186	79		114=	124=	125	135	130	133	155	159		173=	169	151	175=	176	184	194=	217=		206	214	197=
Massey	108	188	213		242	283	299	302	329=	308	343=	346		337	340=	316=	332=	287=	272	284	292		239=	239=	230=
VUW			222		234	227=	229=	225=	237=	237	265=	275=		229=	228=	219	221=	215=	223=	236=	275=		241	244	240=
Canterbury			333		188=	186=	188	189	212	221	238	242		211	214=	214	231=	227=	270=	258	284=		256=	261=	261
Waikato			340		319=	378=	314=	316=	357	374	401-410	401-410		338=	324	292	274	266=	375=	373=	331		250	235	281=
Lincoln											481-490	411-420		373=	343=	319=	317=	356=	387=	372	368		362=	371=	407
AUT										451-500	471-480	501-550		481-490	441-450	441-450	464=	442=	437=	451=	486=		407=	412	410=

Source: QS Quacquarelli Symonds (www.topuniversities.com)
Notes: 1. AUT = Auckland University of Technology, VUW = Victoria University of Wellington. 2. QS has a naming convention where it assigns a year to the name of the ranking that is one year in advance of when it was actually published. For example, the 2026 QS World University Rankings were actually released in June 2025.

Figure 1

QS World University Rankings for New Zealand universities



Notes: 1. We have only graphed occurrences where universities were assigned an individual ranking by QS. 2. VUW = Victoria University of Wellington and AUT = Auckland University of Technology.

Tertiary System Performance Analysis
Te Pou Kaupapahere
Ministry of Education

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